

# BFS Templates — Tree

Core structure: `Queue<TreeNode> queue = new ArrayDeque<>()` .  
The only decision: do you need to know **which level** a node is on?

## The Two Templates

```
// 1. LEVEL-AWARE PROCESSING – snapshot size to make per-level decisions
// MENTAL MODEL: the queue holds exactly one full level; freeze its size, then drain just that many.
// WHEN: "level by level", "per row", "rightmost/leftmost in level", "min depth"
Queue<TreeNode> queue = new ArrayDeque<>();
queue.offer(root);
int level = 0;
while (!queue.isEmpty()) {
    int size = queue.size();          // ← snapshot: all nodes currently in queue = this level
    level++;
    for (int i = 0; i < size; i++) {
        TreeNode node = queue.poll();
        // process node (know: level, i==0 → first, i==size-1 → last)
        if (node.left != null) queue.offer(node.left);
        if (node.right != null) queue.offer(node.right);
    }
}

// 2. WITHOUT LEVEL TRACKING – simple node-by-node
// MENTAL MODEL: just visit every node in BFS order; you don't care which level it's on.
Queue<TreeNode> queue = new ArrayDeque<>();
queue.offer(root);
while (!queue.isEmpty()) {
    TreeNode node = queue.poll();
    // process node
    if (node.left != null) queue.offer(node.left);
    if (node.right != null) queue.offer(node.right);
}
```

Almost all tree BFS problems use **Template 1** — you nearly always need `size` to know when a level ends.

## When to Use — Signal → Pattern

| Problem signal phrase                                             | Pattern / group                                                               |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| "level order", "values per level", "each row"                     | Group 1 — collect entire level                                                |
| "average / max / sum of each level"                               | Group 2 — aggregate per level                                                 |
| "right side view" (last in level), "bottom-left" (first in level) | Group 2 — record boundary node ( <code>i==size-1</code> / <code>i==0</code> ) |
| "minimum depth", "first level that satisfies X"                   | Group 3 — early return on condition                                           |
| "connect next pointers at the same level"                         | Group 4 — wire nodes within a level                                           |
| "same depth, different parent" (cousins), per-node metadata       | Group 5 — track per-node metadata                                             |
| "maximum width of a level" (counting null gaps)                   | Group 6 — position indexing                                                   |
| no level info needed, just visit every node                       | Template 2 — node-by-node                                                     |

## The One Rule — Snapshot Level Size First

Always snapshot the level size BEFORE the inner for loop:

```
int size = queue.size();
for (int i = 0; i < size; i++) { ... }
```

Without the snapshot, newly added children mix with the current level  
and `i == size-1` / `i == 0` checks become meaningless.

Quick Reference Table

| #   | Name                                           | Description                                                                                                                                                                        | Intuition                                                                                               | Time   | Space  | Key Implementation                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
|-----|------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------|--------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 102 | Binary Tree Level Order Traversal              | Return all node values level by level, left to right.                                                                                                                              |                                                                                                         | $O(n)$ | $O(n)$ | Standard                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| 107 | Binary Tree Level Order Traversal II           | Same as #102 but return levels from bottom to top.                                                                                                                                 |                                                                                                         | $O(n)$ | $O(n)$ | Standard                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| 103 | Binary Tree Zigzag Level Order Traversal       | Level 1 left-to-right, level 2 right-to-left, alternating.                                                                                                                         |                                                                                                         | $O(n)$ | $O(n)$ | Standard                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| 637 | Average of Levels in Binary Tree               | Return the average value of nodes at each level.                                                                                                                                   |                                                                                                         | $O(n)$ | $O(n)$ | Standard                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| 199 | Binary Tree Right Side View                    | Return the value of the rightmost node at each level.                                                                                                                              |                                                                                                         | $O(n)$ | $O(n)$ | Standard                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| 513 | Find Bottom Left Tree Value                    | Return the leftmost value in the last level (deepest row).                                                                                                                         |                                                                                                         | $O(n)$ | $O(n)$ | Standard                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| 515 | Find Largest Value in Each Tree Row            | Return the maximum value found at each level.                                                                                                                                      |                                                                                                         | $O(n)$ | $O(n)$ | Standard                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| 116 | Maximum Level Sum of a Binary Tree             | Return the smallest level number (1-indexed) whose node sum is maximum.                                                                                                            |                                                                                                         | $O(n)$ | $O(n)$ | Standard                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| 111 | Minimum Depth of Binary Tree                   | Minimum number of nodes from root to the nearest leaf.                                                                                                                             | BFS reaches nodes in depth order, so the first leaf it dequeues is necessarily the shallowest.          | $O(n)$ | $O(n)$ | Standard                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| 116 | Populating Next Right Pointers in Each Node    | Connect each node's <code>next</code> to the node immediately to its right at the same level. Tree is a perfect binary tree.                                                       | BFS already visits a level left to right, so just chain each node to the one polled before it.          | $O(n)$ | $O(n)$ | Standard                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| 117 | Populating Next Right Pointers in Each Node II | Same as #116 but the tree can be any binary tree (not necessarily perfect).                                                                                                        |                                                                                                         | $O(n)$ | $O(n)$ | Standard                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| 93  | Cousins in Binary Tree                         | Two nodes <code>x</code> and <code>y</code> are cousins if they are at the same depth but have different parents. Return true if <code>x</code> and <code>y</code> are cousins.    | cousins must surface in the <i>same</i> BFS level; if only one shows up per level, their depths differ. | $O(n)$ | $O(n)$ | Standard                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| 662 | Maximum Width of Binary Tree                   | Return the maximum width of any level of a binary tree. Width is defined as the length between the leftmost and rightmost non-null nodes, including all the null nodes in between. |                                                                                                         | $O(n)$ | $O(n)$ | BFS with position tracking. Assign each node a position: root=1, left child of node at pos <code>p</code> gets <code>2*p</code> , right child gets <code>2*p+1</code> . Width of level = <code>lastPos - firstPos + 1</code> . Normalize by subtracting <code>firstPos</code> of each level to prevent overflow. |

Group 1 — Collect Entire Level

#102 Binary Tree Level Order Traversal

**Description:** Return all node values level by level, left to right.

```

class Solution {
    public List<List<Integer>> levelOrder(TreeNode root) {
        List<List<Integer>> result = new ArrayList<>();
        if (root == null) return result;
        Queue<TreeNode> queue = new ArrayDeque<>();
        queue.offer(root);
        while (!queue.isEmpty()) {
            int size = queue.size();
            List<Integer> level = new ArrayList<>();
            for (int i = 0; i < size; i++) {
                TreeNode node = queue.poll();
                level.add(node.val);
                if (node.left != null) queue.offer(node.left);
                if (node.right != null) queue.offer(node.right);
            }
            result.add(level);
        }
        return result;
    }
}

```

**Time**  $O(n)$  | **Space**  $O(n)$

## #107 Binary Tree Level Order Traversal II

**Description:** Same as #102 but return levels from bottom to top.

**Key:** `LinkedList` as result — `addFirst` prepends each level, producing bottom-up order without a final reverse.

```

class Solution {
    public List<List<Integer>> levelOrderBottom(TreeNode root) {
        LinkedList<List<Integer>> result = new LinkedList<>();
        if (root == null) return result;
        Queue<TreeNode> queue = new ArrayDeque<>();
        queue.offer(root);
        while (!queue.isEmpty()) {
            int size = queue.size();
            List<Integer> level = new ArrayList<>();
            for (int i = 0; i < size; i++) {
                TreeNode node = queue.poll();
                level.add(node.val);
                if (node.left != null) queue.offer(node.left);
                if (node.right != null) queue.offer(node.right);
            }
            result.addFirst(level);    // prepend → bottom-up order
        }
        return result;
    }
}

```

**Time**  $O(n)$  | **Space**  $O(n)$

## #103 Binary Tree Zigzag Level Order Traversal

**Description:** Level 1 left-to-right, level 2 right-to-left, alternating.

**Key:** `LinkedList<Integer>` per level as a deque — `addLast` for left-to-right, `addFirst` for right-to-left. Flip flag after each level.

```

class Solution {
    public List<List<Integer>> zigzagLevelOrder(TreeNode root) {
        List<List<Integer>> result = new ArrayList<>();
        if (root == null) return result;
        Queue<TreeNode> queue = new ArrayDeque<>();
        queue.offer(root);
        boolean leftToRight = true;
        while (!queue.isEmpty()) {
            int size = queue.size();
            LinkedList<Integer> level = new LinkedList<>();
            for (int i = 0; i < size; i++) {
                TreeNode node = queue.poll();
                if (leftToRight) {
                    level.addLast(node.val);
                } else {
                    level.addFirst(node.val);
                }
                if (node.left != null) queue.offer(node.left);
                if (node.right != null) queue.offer(node.right);
            }
            result.add(level);
            leftToRight = !leftToRight;
        }
        return result;
    }
}

```

**Time**  $O(n)$  | **Space**  $O(n)$

## #637 Average of Levels in Binary Tree

**Description:** Return the average value of nodes at each level.

```

class Solution {
    public List<Double> averageOfLevels(TreeNode root) {
        List<Double> result = new ArrayList<>();
        Queue<TreeNode> queue = new ArrayDeque<>();
        queue.offer(root);
        while (!queue.isEmpty()) {
            int size = queue.size();
            double sum = 0;
            for (int i = 0; i < size; i++) {
                TreeNode node = queue.poll();
                sum += node.val;
                if (node.left != null) queue.offer(node.left);
                if (node.right != null) queue.offer(node.right);
            }
            result.add(sum / size);
        }
        return result;
    }
}

```

**Time**  $O(n)$  | **Space**  $O(n)$

## Group 2 — Record First / Last / Max in Each Level

All share the same outer loop. Only the `if` inside the `for` changes.

### #199 Binary Tree Right Side View

**Description:** Return the value of the rightmost node at each level.

**Key:** record when `i == size - 1`.

```

class Solution {
    public List<Integer> rightSideView(TreeNode root) {
        List<Integer> result = new ArrayList<>();
        if (root == null) return result;
        Queue<TreeNode> queue = new ArrayDeque<>();
        queue.offer(root);
        while (!queue.isEmpty()) {
            int size = queue.size();
            for (int i = 0; i < size; i++) {
                TreeNode node = queue.poll();
                if (i == size - 1) result.add(node.val);    // last in level
                if (node.left != null) queue.offer(node.left);
                if (node.right != null) queue.offer(node.right);
            }
        }
        return result;
    }
}

```

**Time**  $O(n)$  | **Space**  $O(n)$

---

### #513 Find Bottom Left Tree Value

**Description:** Return the leftmost value in the last level (deepest row).

**Key:** record when `i == 0` every level — after the loop, `bottomLeft` holds the first node of the final level.

```

class Solution {
    public int findBottomLeftValue(TreeNode root) {
        Queue<TreeNode> queue = new ArrayDeque<>();
        queue.offer(root);
        int bottomLeft = root.val;
        while (!queue.isEmpty()) {
            int size = queue.size();
            for (int i = 0; i < size; i++) {
                TreeNode node = queue.poll();
                if (i == 0) bottomLeft = node.val;        // first in level — overwritten each level
                if (node.left != null) queue.offer(node.left);
                if (node.right != null) queue.offer(node.right);
            }
        }
        return bottomLeft;
    }
}

```

**Time**  $O(n)$  | **Space**  $O(n)$

---

### #515 Find Largest Value in Each Tree Row

**Description:** Return the maximum value found at each level.

```

class Solution {
    public List<Integer> largestValues(TreeNode root) {
        List<Integer> result = new ArrayList<>();
        if (root == null) return result;
        Queue<TreeNode> queue = new ArrayDeque<>();
        queue.offer(root);
        while (!queue.isEmpty()) {
            int size = queue.size();
            int max = Integer.MIN_VALUE;
            for (int i = 0; i < size; i++) {
                TreeNode node = queue.poll();
                max = Math.max(max, node.val);
                if (node.left != null) queue.offer(node.left);
                if (node.right != null) queue.offer(node.right);
            }
            result.add(max);
        }
        return result;
    }
}

```

**Time**  $O(n)$  | **Space**  $O(n)$

## #1161 Maximum Level Sum of a Binary Tree

**Description:** Return the smallest level number (1-indexed) whose node sum is maximum.

```

class Solution {
    public int maxLevelSum(TreeNode root) {
        Queue<TreeNode> queue = new ArrayDeque<>();
        queue.offer(root);
        int maxSum = Integer.MIN_VALUE, maxLevel = 1, level = 0;
        while (!queue.isEmpty()) {
            int size = queue.size();
            level++;
            int sum = 0;
            for (int i = 0; i < size; i++) {
                TreeNode node = queue.poll();
                sum += node.val;
                if (node.left != null) queue.offer(node.left);
                if (node.right != null) queue.offer(node.right);
            }
            if (sum > maxSum) { maxSum = sum; maxLevel = level; }
        }
        return maxLevel;
    }
}

```

**Time**  $O(n)$  | **Space**  $O(n)$

## Group 3 — Early Return on Condition

### #111 Minimum Depth of Binary Tree

**Description:** Minimum number of nodes from root to the nearest leaf.

**Key:** BFS is optimal here (DFS must visit the whole tree). Return `depth` the moment the first leaf is dequeued — that is guaranteed to be the shallowest.

**Intuition:** BFS reaches nodes in depth order, so the first leaf it dequeues is necessarily the shallowest.

```

class Solution {
    public int minDepth(TreeNode root) {
        if (root == null) return 0;
        Queue<TreeNode> queue = new ArrayDeque<>();
        queue.offer(root);
        int depth = 0;
        while (!queue.isEmpty()) {
            int size = queue.size();
            depth++;
            for (int i = 0; i < size; i++) {
                TreeNode node = queue.poll();
                if (node.left == null && node.right == null) return depth; // first leaf
                if (node.left != null) queue.offer(node.left);
                if (node.right != null) queue.offer(node.right);
            }
        }
        return depth;
    }
}

```

**Time**  $O(n)$  | **Space**  $O(n)$

## Group 4 — Connect Nodes Within a Level

### #116 Populating Next Right Pointers in Each Node

**Description:** Connect each node's `next` to the node immediately to its right at the same level. Tree is a perfect binary tree.

**Key:** `previous` tracks the last node seen in the current level — wire `previous.next = node` before advancing. Reset `previous = null` at each level start.

**Intuition:** BFS already visits a level left to right, so just chain each node to the one polled before it.

```

class Solution {
    public Node connect(Node root) {
        if (root == null) return null;
        Queue<Node> queue = new ArrayDeque<>();
        queue.offer(root);
        while (!queue.isEmpty()) {
            int size = queue.size();
            Node previous = null;
            for (int i = 0; i < size; i++) {
                Node node = queue.poll();
                if (previous != null) previous.next = node;
                previous = node;
                if (node.left != null) queue.offer(node.left);
                if (node.right != null) queue.offer(node.right);
            }
        }
        return root;
    }
}

```

**Time**  $O(n)$  | **Space**  $O(n)$

### #117 Populating Next Right Pointers in Each Node II

**Description:** Same as #116 but the tree can be any binary tree (not necessarily perfect).

**Key:** the BFS solution is **identical** to #116 — the `size` snapshot handles uneven levels automatically.

```

class Solution {
    public Node connect(Node root) {
        if (root == null) return null;
        Queue<Node> queue = new ArrayDeque<>();
        queue.offer(root);
        while (!queue.isEmpty()) {
            int size = queue.size();
            Node previous = null;
            for (int i = 0; i < size; i++) {
                Node node = queue.poll();
                if (previous != null) previous.next = node;
                previous = node;
                if (node.left != null) queue.offer(node.left);
                if (node.right != null) queue.offer(node.right);
            }
        }
        return root;
    }
}

```

**Time**  $O(n)$  | **Space**  $O(n)$

## Group 5 — Track Per-Node Metadata

### #993 Cousins in Binary Tree

**Description:** Two nodes `x` and `y` are cousins if they are at the same depth but have different parents. Return true if `x` and `y` are cousins.

**Key:** for each node polled, check if its children are `x` or `y`. After each full level, if both parents found → check `xParent != yParent`. If only one found → different depths → false.

**Intuition:** cousins must surface in the *same* BFS level; if only one shows up per level, their depths differ.

```

class Solution {
    public boolean isCousins(TreeNode root, int x, int y) {
        Queue<TreeNode> queue = new ArrayDeque<>();
        queue.offer(root);
        while (!queue.isEmpty()) {
            int size = queue.size();
            TreeNode xParent = null, yParent = null;
            for (int i = 0; i < size; i++) {
                TreeNode node = queue.poll();
                if (node.left != null) {
                    queue.offer(node.left);
                    if (node.left.val == x) xParent = node;
                    if (node.left.val == y) yParent = node;
                }
                if (node.right != null) {
                    queue.offer(node.right);
                    if (node.right.val == x) xParent = node;
                    if (node.right.val == y) yParent = node;
                }
            }
            if (xParent != null && yParent != null) return xParent != yParent;
            if (xParent != null || yParent != null) return false; // one found → different depths
        }
        return false;
    }
}

```

**Time**  $O(n)$  | **Space**  $O(n)$

## Side-by-Side: 199 vs 513

Both record one node per level. The only difference is which node:



|                   |                                   |                                                |
|-------------------|-----------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|
|                   | #199 Right Side View              | #513 Bottom Left Value                         |
| Record condition: | <code>i == size - 1 (last)</code> | <code>i == 0 (first)</code>                    |
| Update per level: | <code>result.add(node.val)</code> | <code>bottomLeft = node.val (overwrite)</code> |
| Return:           | <code>List&lt;Integer&gt;</code>  | <code>bottomLeft</code> after all levels done  |

## Side-by-Side: 102 vs 103 vs 107

All collect every node in every level. Only the insertion order changes:

|                  |                                       |                                        |                                       |
|------------------|---------------------------------------|----------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|
|                  | #102 Level Order                      | #103 Zigzag                            | #107 Bottom-Up                        |
| Level container: | <code>ArrayList&lt;Integer&gt;</code> | <code>LinkedList&lt;Integer&gt;</code> | <code>ArrayList&lt;Integer&gt;</code> |
| Add node:        | <code>level.add(val)</code>           | <code>addLast/addFirst</code>          | <code>level.add(val)</code>           |
| Add to result:   | <code>result.add(level)</code>        | <code>result.add(level)</code>         | <code>result.addFirst(level)</code>   |
| Extra state:     | <code>-</code>                        | <code>boolean leftToRight</code>       | <code>result is LinkedList</code>     |

## Pattern Summary

| What changes per level | Key variable                                          | Example problems |
|------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|------------------|
| Collect all values     | <code>List&lt;Integer&gt; level</code>                | 102, 107, 103    |
| Compute aggregate      | <code>int sum / int max</code>                        | 637, 515, 1161   |
| Record boundary node   | check <code>i == 0</code> or <code>i == size-1</code> | 199, 513         |
| Return on first match  | <code>return depth</code>                             | 111              |
| Wire nodes together    | <code>Node previous</code>                            | 116, 117         |
| Track parent metadata  | <code>TreeNode xParent, yParent</code>                | 993              |

## The One Rule (recap)

Snapshot the level size **before** the inner `for` loop — see "The One Rule" at the top of this file for the full explanation.

## Group 6 — Position Indexing

### #662 Maximum Width of Binary Tree

**Description:** Return the maximum width of any level of a binary tree. Width is defined as the length between the leftmost and rightmost non-null nodes, including all the null nodes in between.

**Variation:** BFS with position tracking. Assign each node a position: root=1, left child of node at pos `p` gets `2*p`, right child gets `2*p+1`. Width of level = `lastPos - firstPos + 1`. Normalize by subtracting `firstPos` of each level to prevent overflow.

```

class Solution {
    public int widthOfBinaryTree(TreeNode root) {
        if (root == null) return 0;
        int maxWidth = 0;
        List<TreeNode> nodes = new ArrayList<>();
        List<Long> positions = new ArrayList<>();
        nodes.add(root);
        positions.add(1L);
        while (!nodes.isEmpty()) {
            int size = nodes.size();
            long start = positions.get(0);
            maxWidth = (int) Math.max(maxWidth, positions.get(size-1) - start + 1);
            List<TreeNode> nextNodes = new ArrayList<>();
            List<Long> nextPositions = new ArrayList<>();
            for (int i = 0; i < size; i++) {
                TreeNode node = nodes.get(i);
                long pos = positions.get(i) - start;    // ← VARIATION: normalize to prevent overflow
                if (node.left != null) {
                    nextNodes.add(node.left);
                    nextPositions.add(2 * pos);          // ← VARIATION: left child = 2*pos
                }
                if (node.right != null) {
                    nextNodes.add(node.right);
                    nextPositions.add(2 * pos + 1);      // ← VARIATION: right child = 2*pos+1
                }
            }
            nodes = nextNodes;
            positions = nextPositions;
        }
        return maxWidth;
    }
}

```

**Time**  $O(n)$  | **Space**  $O(n)$